

not in the one-to-one messaging window. Anyhow, those are painfully irritating and obtrusive. Still, overall a very solid and reliable chat client.

ICQ 5.04 (Lite)

ICQ was the first IM client that became popular. With its new, clean-and-intuitive interface, it still has its cult following in large numbers. ICQ Lite has all the essential features of the full version.

It has the standard features that all other good IMs like MSN and Yahoo! have. You can message people, exchange files, send SMS messages, and voice chat. It includes multilingual support and the ability to save chat histories. A typing indicator indicates when a contact is typing a message.



The SMS service, though not very reliable, does not require registration with the service provider, but there are limitations depending upon what region you're in. ICQ Xtraz is a very neat feature that lets you send cool, personalised ICQ greeting cards. These stand out from the usual e-greetings you find on the Net.

The basic chat window is full of features. It makes the sound of an old typewriter when you're typing text, which is an interesting feature but can be annoying if you're chatting while listening to music! Like with all good features, you have the option to switch it off. The real stand-out feature is "Buzz It", which is present in the Xtraz sidebar. It lets you send messages to multiple recipients at once. By enhancing its features and adding the new Xtraz side tab, ICQ is once again applying for the position of "best chatting software".